

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1987-06-15

To two individual bahá'ís

1 dear bahá'í friends,
2 your letter of 11 April 1987, signed by yourselves, . . . , and . . . , has been
3 convey the following response to you.
4 The house of justice is deeply concerned at the plight of so many of the
5 indigenous and aboriginal peoples in various parts of the world who have
6 been denied their rights as a consequence of actions by oppressive majorities. Such
inequities and injustices are to be found in many countries. The purpose of the coming of
bahá'u'lláh is to lift the yoke of oppression from
7 his loved ones, to liberate all the people of the world, and to provide the
8 means for their abiding happiness.

The bahá'í approach to resolution of the manifold problems affecting

9 human society rests upon the assertion by bahá'u'lláh that these ills are
10 but various symptoms and side effects of the basic disease, which the divine
physician has diagnosed to be disunity. bahá'u'lláh has made it
11 abundantly clear that the first step essential for the health and harmony of the whole
of mankind is its unification. he says, "The well-being
12 of mankind, its peace and security are unattainable unless and until its unity is firmly
established" (The World Order of Bahá'u'lláh, p. 203). by
13 contrast, the approach of most people is the exact opposite: their concentration is on
attempts to remedy the multitude of ills besetting man-
14 kind, with the expectation that the resolution of these problems will lead
15 ultimately to unity.
16 This unity can only be achieved through the spreading of the faith and
17 the building up of the world order of bahá'u'lláh. bahá'u'lláh states in

Gleanings, Section 120:28.3

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30 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

31 56 That which the lord hath ordained as the sovereign remedy and

mightiest instrument for the healing of all the world is the union of

all its peoples in one universal cause, one common faith. This can

in no wise be achieved except through the power of a skilled, an all-

32 powerful and inspired physician. This, verily, is the truth, and all else

33 naught but error.

34 As Shoghi e f f e n d i states in The World Order of Bahá'u'lláh, p. 34:

what else, might we not confidently affirm, but the unreserved ac-

ceptance of the divine program enunciated, with such simplicity

and force as far back as sixty years ago, by bahá'u'lláh, embodying

in its essentials god's divinely appointed scheme for the unification

of mankind in this age, coupled with an indomitable conviction in

35 the unfailing efficacy of each and all of its provisions, is eventually capable of
withstanding the forces of internal disintegration which, if unchecked, must needs continue
to eat into the vitals of a despairing

36 society. . . .

37 Such an effort is frequently misunderstood by others who feel that the

38 bahá'ís are not concentrating on solving the immediate and pressing prob-

39 lems. This concern was addressed by the house of justice in a letter written

40 on 19 November 1974 to a National Spiritual Assembly:

. . . bahá'ís are often accused of holding aloof from the "real prob-

lems" of their fellow-men. but when we hear this accusation let us

41 not forget that those who make it are usually idealistic materialists to

whom material good is the only "real" good, whereas we know that

the working of the material world is merely a reflection of spiritual

42 conditions and until the spiritual conditions can be changed there can be no lasting
change for the better in material affairs.

we should also remember that most people have no clear concept

43 of the sort of world they wish to build, nor how to go about building it. even those
who are concerned to improve conditions are therefore

44 reduced to combating every apparent evil that takes their attention.

willingness to fight against evils, whether in the form of conditions

or embodied in evil men, has thus become for most people the touch-

45 stone by which they judge a person's moral worth. bahá'ís, on the 29.4a

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30 1986–1992 • The Six Year Plan

31 57other hand, know the goal they are working towards and know what

32 they must do, step by step, to attain it. Their whole energy is directed

towards the building of the good, a good which has such a positive

33 strength that in the face of it the multitude of evils—which are in essence
negative—will fade away and be no more. To enter into the quixotic tournament of
demolishing one by one the evils in the world

34 is, to a bahá'í, a vain waste of time and effort. his whole life is directed

35 towards proclaiming the message of bahá'u'lláh, reviving the spiritual

36 life of his fellow-men, uniting them in a divinely created world order,

and then, as that order grows in strength and influence, he will see

the power of that message transforming the whole human society and

progressively solving the problems and removing the injustices which

37 have so long bedeviled the world.

38 29-1

39 it is contrary to bahá'í principles for a believer to resort to partisan politi-

40 cal action in asserting his rights or in seeking to obtain justice. it would be

41 quite wrong for a bahá'í to take up arms for a cause he or she believes to be

42 just; such an action would be a direct contradiction of the aims of the faith
 43 and of its laws. believers are enjoined to deepen themselves more fully in the
 44 principles of world order expounded by Shoghi effendi in his writings, so
 45 that they will gradually come to understand the underlying cause of the op-pression
 of minorities, as well as the spiritual forces released by bahá'u'lláh
 46 and animating the work of the bahá'í community in laboriously erecting
 47 and perfecting the administrative institutions which are the means by which
 48 justice is being established in the world.
 49 bahá'ís are free to work within the existing political and legal system.
 50 There is no objection to any bahá'í's making a legal claim to property or
 51 rights through the courts or administrative agencies to which he has access.

with the emergence of the faith from obscurity, there are increasing

52 opportunities to bring bahá'í principles to the attention of governments and
 53 to offer advice in the promotion of human rights. it is essential that such
 54 endeavors be carried out under the aegis of the National Spiritual Assembly.
 55 The believers are free to make suggestions to their National Assemblies or to
 recommend a course of action, but they must trust in the wisdom of their National Spiritual
 Assemblies to decide whether or not such action is

56 appropriate.

57 29-1. muhj, no. 151.6-7 .29.6

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30 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

31 58The house of justice hopes the above makes clear the bahá'í position
 32 on the important issue raised in your letter. w e are asked to assure you that
 33 prayers will be offered at the Sacred Threshold for all those concerned with
 34 this distressing problem.

35 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

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Conduct of a National Convention

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]